



Guide to Redesigning the Instructional Designer (L&D) Job in the Age of AI

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How to Use

- CHROs — use this tool as a guide to:
 - Determine when to redesign the instructional designer (L&D) job
 - Decide on the balance of AI autonomy and human involvement required in instructional designer workflows
 - Redefine the instructional designer job including ways of working, the work to be done, and who does the work
 - Upskill and source talent for new skills and competencies
 - Support instructional designers through the transition
- *The guidance in this tool is a starting point — use your organization's context (business need, budget, AI-readiness) and your current instructional designer job description as input for the redesign steps.*

Track Signals to Know When it's Time to Redesign the Job

The signals below indicate changes to the instructional designer job. When you reach the more disruptive signals, it is time to fully redesign the job, but don't wait to act. Start addressing the capability gaps and demand shifts today.

Less
Disruptive

- ❑ **Demand for Strategic Advisory Surges:** Business leaders increasingly seek L&D's partnership to build strategic capability and workforce readiness, not just standard training modules
- ❑ **Personalization and Volume Demands Escalate:** Stakeholders request more learning support and expect hyperpersonalized, adaptive learning delivered at the speed of need, not just static, linear content creation
- ❑ **Stakeholders Demand ROI Over "Completion Rates":** Business leaders now expect clear proof of ROI and a direct connection between learning activities and enterprise value.
- ❑ **Capability Gaps Emerge:** Skills required for high-value instructional design work (e.g., AI fluency, product management, learning analytics) are not present in the current team.
- ❑ **Access and Availability of AI Tools Increases:** The organization has invested in the tools that take on tasks and workflows previously completed by instructional designers.
- ❑ **The Emergence of "AI Slop":** You begin to notice the production of low-quality, inaccurate, or generic AI-generated learning content ("AI slop") that indicates the team isn't set up effectively to deliver
- ❑ **Routine Tasks Become Fully Automated:** Tasks that traditionally consume the bulk of an instructional designer's time—such as creating content, generating quizzes, formatting, checking for accessibility, and making basic course updates—can be easily streamlined and automated by AI tools

More
Disruptive

The Path to Instructional Designer Job Redesign

1. Plan Support for the Instructional Designer Change Journey

- Help instructional designers let go of existing workflows and embrace new ones.
- Anticipate and address behavioral byproducts (the knock-on behaviors both positive and negative) of adding AI to work.

2. Deconstruct the Job into Key Workflows

- Work with instructional designers to build a list of their workflows and tasks
- Consider the workflows that are
 - Core to the job
 - Contextual based on seniority, experience etc.
 - Shared, cross-functional responsibilities

3. Balance Human and AI Elements In Workflows

- Identify which workflows it is safe for AI to automate and which need human judgment.
- Probe for both risk and opportunity.

4. Redefine the Human Value in the Job

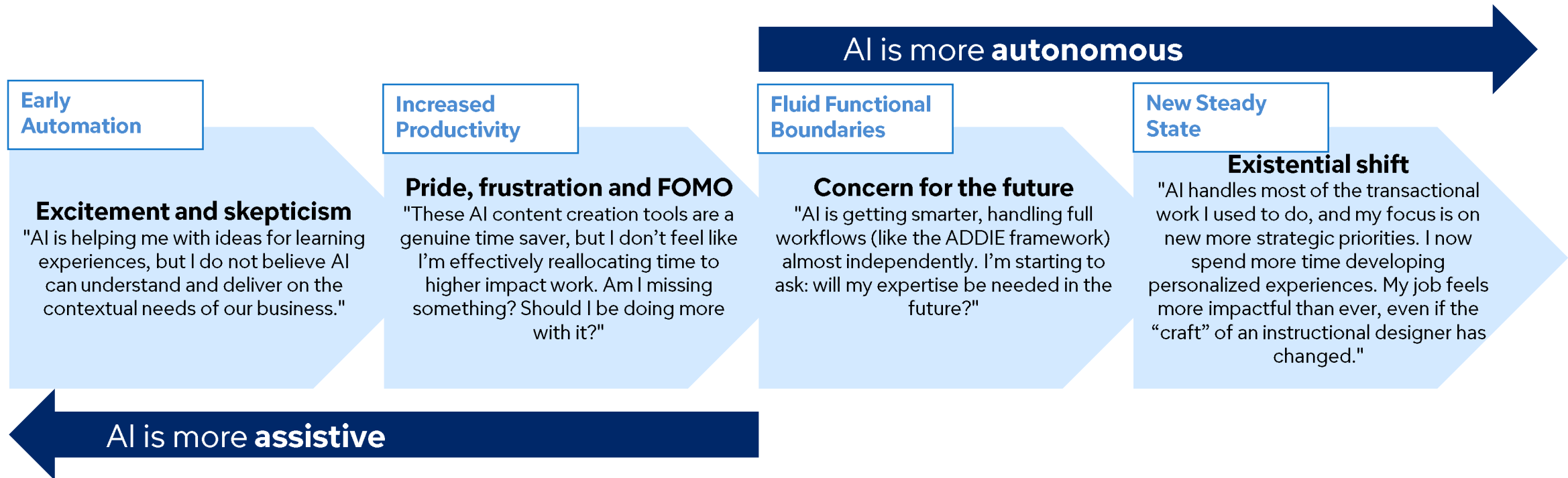
- With clarity on what will be automated, redesign the job through three lenses:
 - The job to be done
 - Who does the job
 - Ways of working

5. Source and Upskill for Evolving Competencies

- Evaluate how new workflows will change instructional designer competencies.
- Identify core competencies, competencies growing in importance and new competencies required.
- Reset performance expectations and build upskilling and sourcing plans for new instructional designer talent.

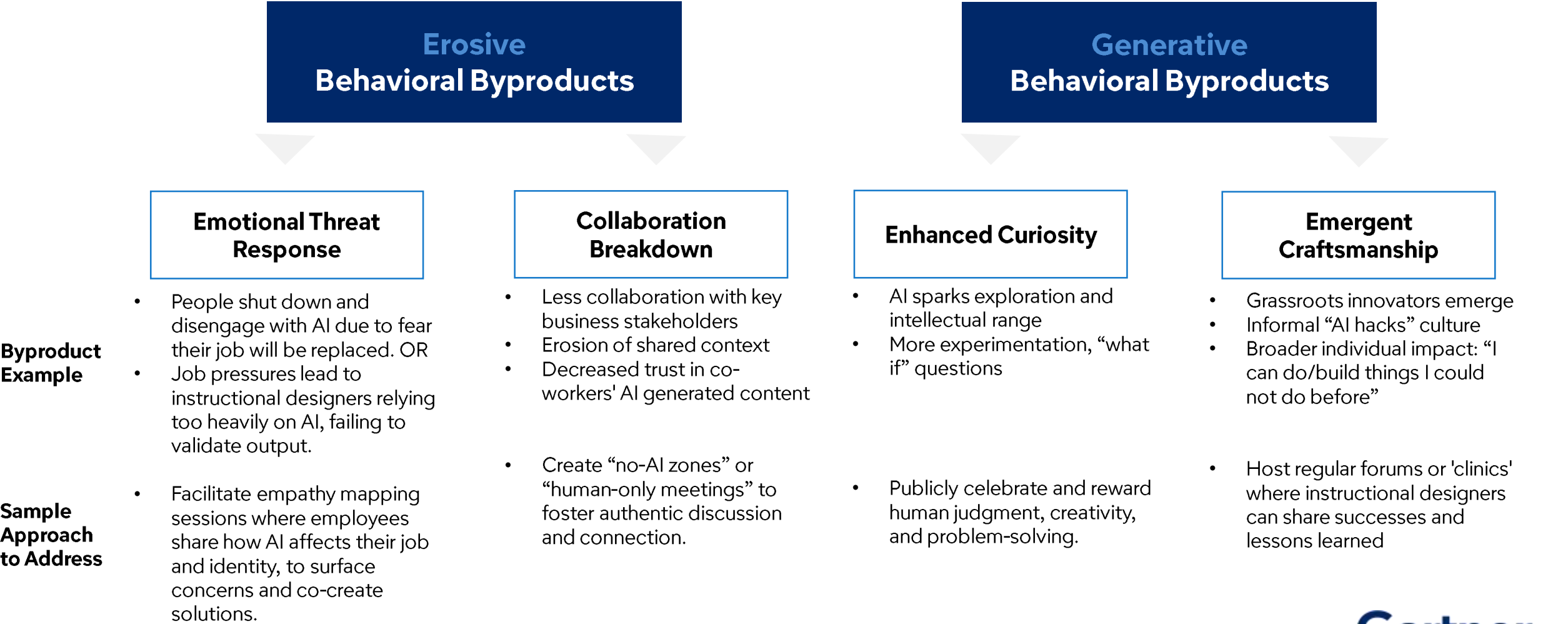
The Human Emotional Journey: From Excitement to Doubt to Existential Shift

As instructional designers use AI more often in their job, and begin to see their responsibilities shift, they will move through an emotional journey as outlined below. Acknowledge where your instructional designers are on this journey and provide the appropriate change management and communication tools to support progress toward their new steady state.



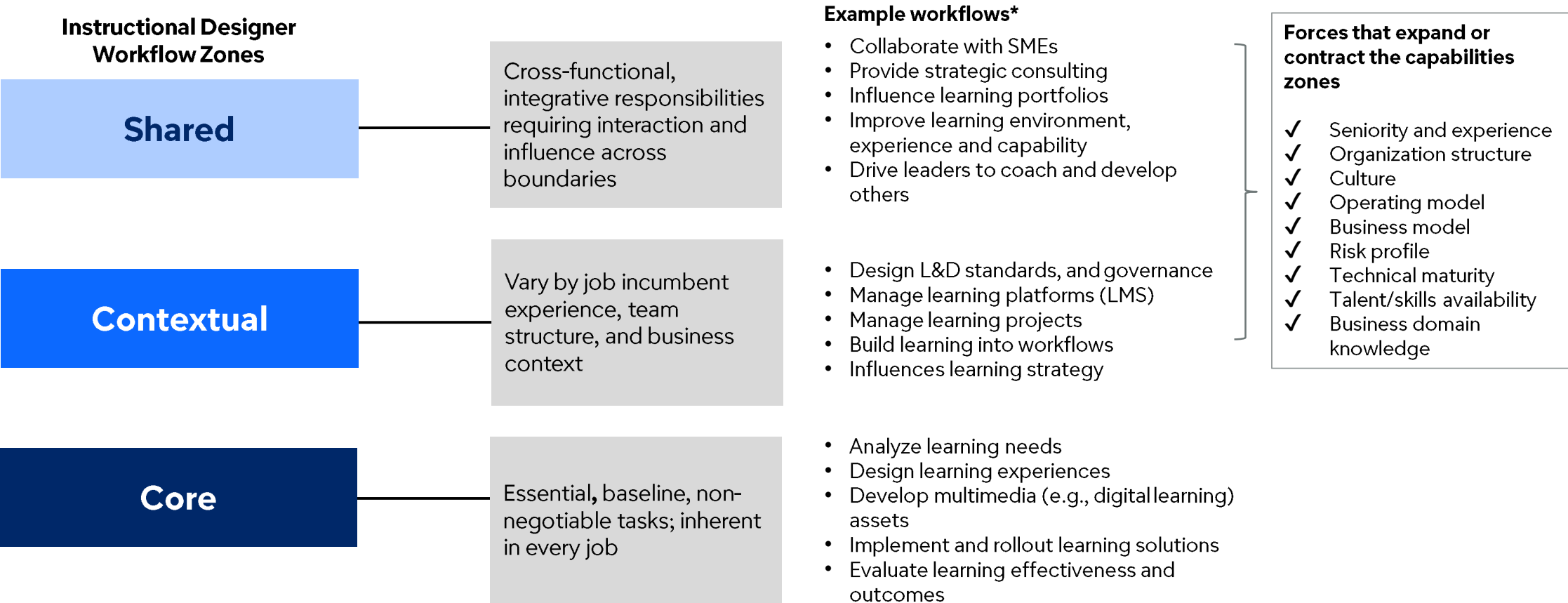
Manage the Behavioral Side Effects of AI Transformation

As AI becomes embedded into workflows, behavioral byproducts will start to appear. Some will pose threats to productivity and quality, while others create new paths to value. Use this guidance to mitigate erosive byproducts and harness generative byproducts.



Deconstruct the Instructional Designer Job

Use this guide as a starting point to map your instructional designers' core, contextual and shared capabilities. You will use these workflows in the next step when evaluating how AI will change how this work gets done. Below you will find an example (non-exhaustive) workflow list.



* Examples reflect workflows found in current designs of an instructional designer job.

Anticipate Levels of AI* Autonomy

This pathway highlights the anticipated levels of AI autonomy and human involvement required in instructional designer workflows

L1: Static, Disconnected Assistant

- GenAI tools complete tasks as requested by instructional designers — draft course descriptions, generate learning content images, translate text, or create basic quiz questions.
- Instructional designers manually review, prompt, and contextualize outputs into training materials, relying on their own judgment for all decisions.

L2: Embedded Helper

- AI becomes integrated into LMS tools and platforms, automatically generating course templates, suggesting learning paths, or providing basic learner feedback analytics.
- Instructional designers interact with AI recommendations within their daily workflows, using them to accelerate creation but retaining full control over final design and pedagogical effectiveness.

L3: Task-Specific Automation

- AI autonomously handles high-volume, rule-based design tasks — such as curating basic training content, autogenerating standard e-learning modules, formatting, and checking for accessibility.
- Instructional designers monitor output for accuracy and "AI slop," intervening only for complex learning needs, freeing them up to focus on strategic learning experience design and creative problem solving.

L4: Operational Collaborator

- Specialized AI agents support L&D workflows (e.g., an instructional design agent maps objectives to content, an LMS publishing agent validates and publishes modules, another consolidates training analytics).
- Instructional designers act as "context engineers," applying pedagogical rules, knowledge systems, and creating exemplars for agents. They supervise outputs, validate quality, and manage stakeholder relationships.

L5: Creative, Multiagent Environments

- Multiple AI agents dynamically coordinate across L&D domains — jointly performing real-time skills gap analysis, autogenerating hyperpersonalized adaptive learning paths, and delivering just-in-time microbursts.
- Instructional designers set product design strategy, oversee agent governance, and evaluate overall portfolio impact on business KPIs. Humans are still required to partner with the business on building critical strategic capabilities.

The AI Exposure Heat Map for the Instructional Designer Job

Just because something *could* be automated, doesn't mean it *should* be automated. Fill in the workflows you defined on the previous page and decide the balance of acceptable AI autonomy vs. human involvement for each workflow and their related tasks. Consider both your access to AI tools and the readiness of the team to adopt them. When significant amounts of work can be completed by AI (white/light blue in table), it's time to redesign the job.

Workflows		L1: Static, Disconnected Assistant	L2: Embedded Helper	L3: Task-Specific Automation	L4: Operational Collaborator	L5: Creative, Multiagent Environments
Core	Analyze learning needs					
	Design learning experiences					
	Develop multimedia assets					
	Implement/rollout learning solutions					
	Evaluate learning effectiveness					
Contextual	Design L&D standards & governance					
	Manage learning platforms (LMS)					
	Manage learning projects					
	Build learning into workflows					
	Influence learning strategy					
Shared	Collaborate with SMEs					
	Provide strategic consulting					
	Influence learning portfolios					
	Improve learning environment, experience and capability					
	Drive leaders to coach/develop					

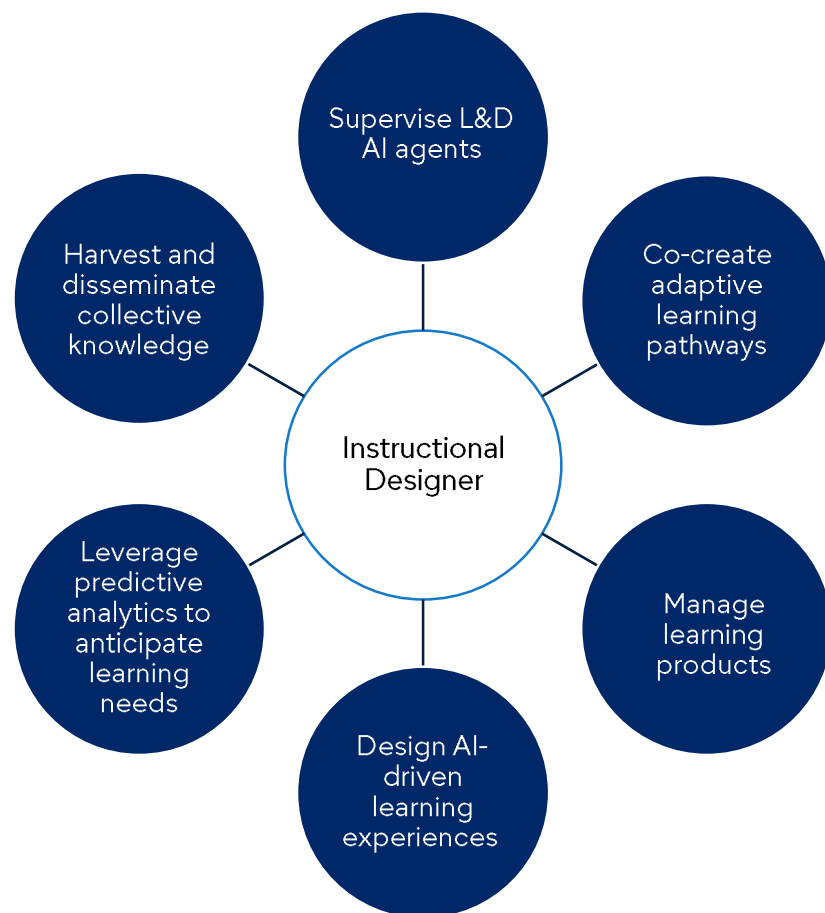
- Consider:**
- The nature of the task (judgment vs. rules based)
 - The risk level of AI getting it wrong
 - The unique human value add
 - The impact on the 'customer' if it were to be automated

AI Exposure Heatmap :

- Highly automatable (AI/agents can perform most tasks independently)
- AI does most work; human oversight needed
- Shared responsibility (routine automated; humans handle complex parts)
- Mostly human; AI automates minor repetitive tasks
- Fully human-centric; AI impact is minimal

Expand, Don't Shrink the Value Instructional Designers Provide

Automation will shrink the need for the instructional designer job as it is today, but it also offers the opportunity to provide new strategic value to the business. Use your evolving business needs and priorities to identify new capabilities and a new value proposition for the instructional designer job. See below for examples.



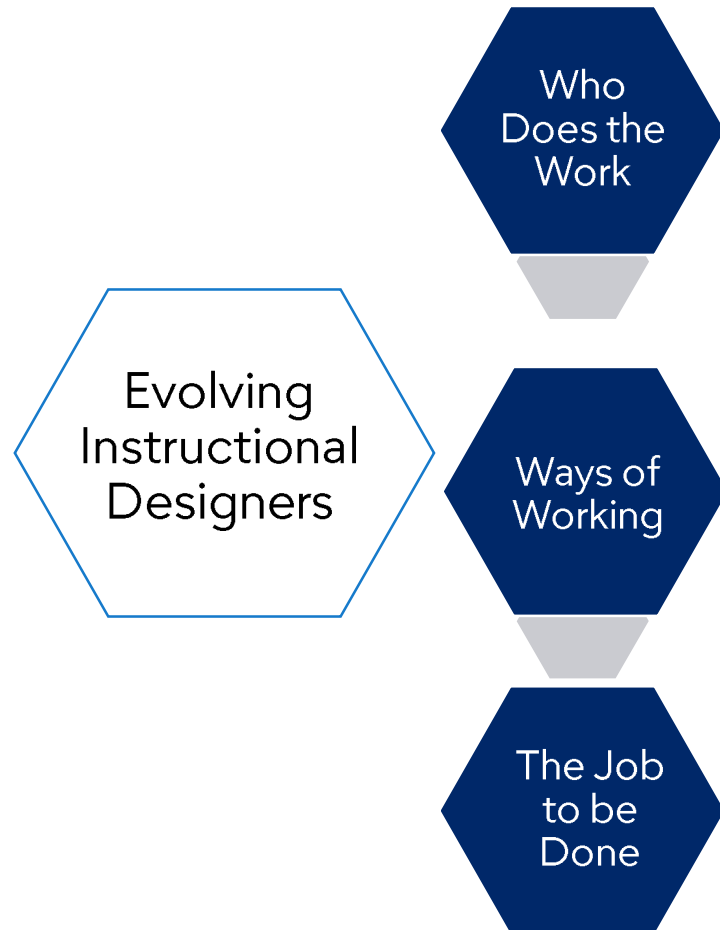
Gartner Position:

By 2029, the traditional instructional designer job will cease to exist in progressive organizations.

As AI fully automates basic content curation, L&D leaders must aggressively **transition these roles into L&D Product Designers** whose primary value is managing a portfolio of learning solutions to build strategic capability, drive workforce readiness, and support AI-ready learners.

Redefine the Human's Role in the Instructional Designer Job

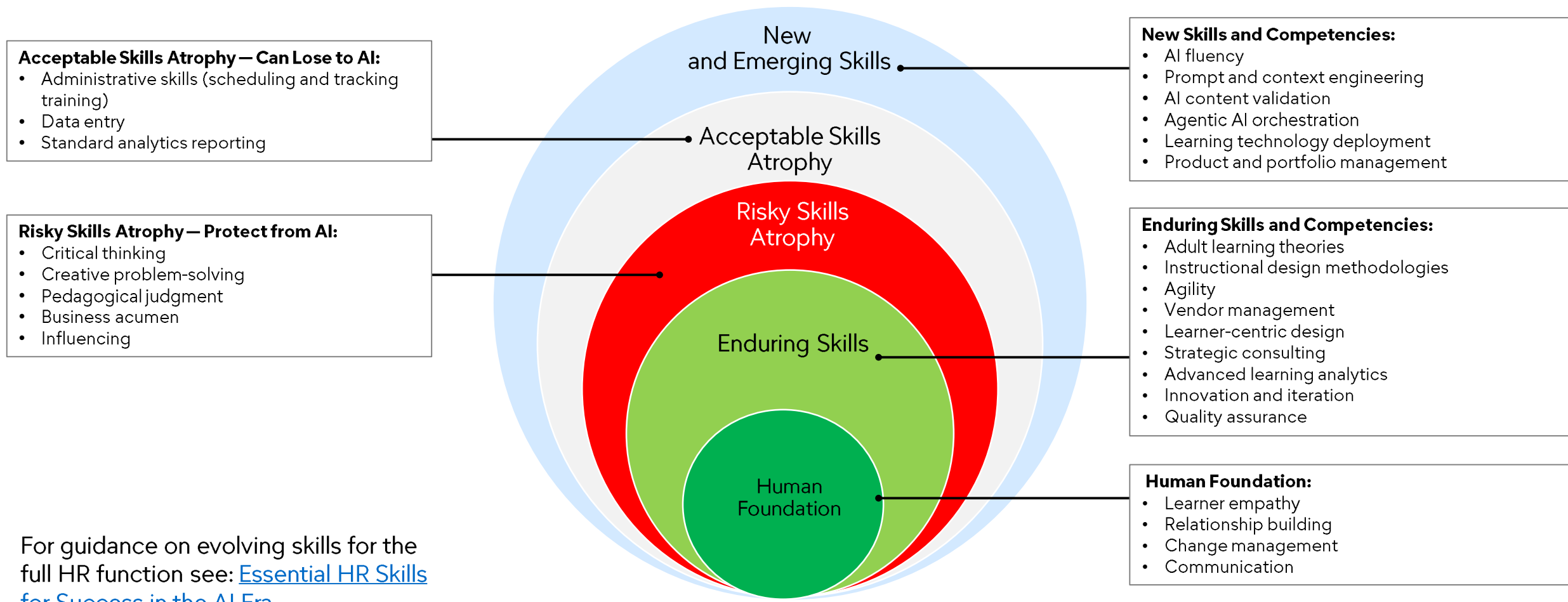
As AI absorbs routine content creation, the instructional designer is elevated from a traditional course builder into a strategic orchestrator of tech-enabled learning. This transformation demands a shift in responsibilities and ways of working. Use Gartner's recommendations below to redesign your instructional designer job



- **AI Agents and Tools:** AI autonomously handles production tasks like curating basic content, generating quizzes, and formatting. Instructional designers step out of content generation to act as guardians who supervise AI agents and validate outputs.
- **Multidisciplinary Fusion Teams:** Instructional designers no longer work in silos; they collaborate dynamically with IT developers, product managers, and business SMEs to build and scale learning products.
- **Agile Sprints Over Linear Projects:** Shifting from slow, traditional frameworks, like ADDIE, (analyze, design, develop, implement, evaluate) to rapid, iterative sprints that prioritize delivering learning "minimum viable products" (MVPs) at the speed of need.
- **Collective Knowledge Harvesting:** Moving away from creating all content from scratch to continuously harvesting and distributing real-time expertise from internal subject matter experts across the organization.
- **Orchestrate Adaptive Learning:** Transitioning from delivering static, one-size-fits-all courses to managing dynamic, hyperpersonalized learning pathways driven by learner data and skills gaps.
- **Ensure Pedagogical Quality:** Embedding learning science into AI workflows to prevent low-quality, generic "AI slop" and ensuring content drives actual behavior change and knowledge retention.

What Stays Human, What Changes, What's Next

As the work of the instructional designer changes, their competencies will also evolve. Use this guide to decide what competencies to preserve and develop for future impact.



For guidance on evolving skills for the full HR function see: [Essential HR Skills for Success in the AI Era](#)

Sourcing/Reskilling Strategy for the Job

Use this guidance to create a sourcing and upskilling plan for the redesigned Instructional Designer job.

Evaluate the Shifting Demand and Capability Gaps

- **Reset Expectations:** Clearly articulate the new deliverables and required skill sets for the new instructional designer job.
- **Assess Competencies:** Evaluate the current instructional designers' interest and capability to transition from being the primary originators of content to acting as "human-on-the-loop" quality validators and product managers.
- **Anticipate Headcount Shifts:** Recognize that as AI absorbs routine tasks like standard e-learning creation and content formatting, the overall need for traditional content creators will decrease, while the demand for strategic, tech-enabled learning orchestrators will rise.

Implement Targeted Upskilling Programs

- **Launch Product Management "Literacy Labs":** Implement structured, interactive workshops designed to teach instructional designers the fundamentals of agile product management through experiential, project-based learning.
- **Establish IT-L&D Rotations:** Create "shared development" contracts and job rotations between L&D and IT business partners to cross-pollinate talent, helping instructional designers build hands-on technical proficiency with AI and data ecosystems.

Redefine Sourcing and Mobility Pathways

- **Source Cross-Functional Talent:** Look beyond traditional L&D backgrounds to source individuals with expertise in data analytics, IT, and product management to help staff the multidisciplinary "fusion teams" needed to build dynamic, AI-enabled learning products.
- **Leverage Internal Talent Marketplaces (ITMs):** Utilize ITMs to source employees from across the organization for short-term "gig assignments" or "flex projects" within L&D fusion teams, allowing the L&D function to rapidly access diverse, cross-functional skills without needing to change permanent headcount.